

STAGE FOURTEEN • PROJECT MANAGEMENT

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Fourteen • Project Management

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Fourteen is more procedural than most stages, which brings its own facilitation challenge: keeping the content from feeling dry or purely academic. This script leans on grounding every transition in the participant's own real project, not abstract project management theory.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck or hesitant.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

"Welcome to Stage Fourteen. You've already been managing projects informally for years — group assignments, personal goals, even planning an event. Today we start formalizing that instinct with a genuine framework."

"Throughout this stage, I want you working with one real project, not a different hypothetical example for every exercise. Pick something current, upcoming, or recently finished — school, work, or personal, it doesn't matter, as long as it's real."

Opening Session 2

"Last time was entirely about planning before anything starts moving. Today, we manage the real, moving parts — stakeholders, communication, budget, schedule — once a project is actually underway."

"Bring back your planning documents from last session. Everything today builds directly on the project you defined then."

Opening Session 3 (Stage Close)

"Our final session covers two different things: modern methodologies like Agile, Scrum, and Kanban, and the formal practices that properly close out a project. Don't worry if you have no direct Agile experience yet — awareness is the goal today, not mastery."

"We'll close by having you commit to managing one real project end-to-end, from initiation through formal closure, using everything from this entire stage."

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST R3 → R4

"You've drawn a clear boundary around what's in and out of scope. Now let's make sure what's inside that boundary is actually what stakeholders genuinely need, not just what they initially asked for."

FIRST R7 → R8

"You've broken the work into assignable pieces. Before assigning anything, let's confirm the people, tools, and budget those pieces actually require are genuinely available."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Everything today was about planning before anything starts. Next session, the project is actually moving — and moving projects need active management, not just a good plan."

FIRST R14 → R15

"You've learned to verify a milestone was genuinely met, not just that the date passed. Now let's look at what happens when someone wants to change what 'genuinely met' even means — a scope change."

FIRST R17 → R18

"You've taken real action on a risk instead of just documenting it. Budgets need the same discipline — tracked and acted on, not just estimated once and forgotten."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You now know how to plan a project and manage it once it's moving. Our final session looks at how modern teams actually structure that movement, and how every project should properly end."

FIRST R23 → R24

"You've seen three different ways to structure work: traditional, Scrum, Kanban. Regardless of which structure a project uses, it still needs honest, regular review — that's next."

FIRST R28 → R29

"You've formally closed a project, confirming every deliverable was genuinely met. Before moving on, let's capture what that project taught you, specifically enough that a future project can actually use it."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

A participant's "real project" feels too small or informal to take seriously

"Size doesn't matter here — the discipline is the same whether it's a multi-million dollar initiative or planning a family reunion. Pick whatever real project you have, and apply the same rigor."

Someone struggles to name a genuine risk for their project (FIRST R9)

"Think about what would genuinely embarrass or delay you if it happened. That's usually a real risk, even if it feels obvious once named."

A participant treats Agile/Scrum/Kanban as inherently superior to traditional planning

"Each approach fits certain kinds of work better than others. The skill isn't picking a favorite — it's recognizing which structure actually fits the project in front of you."

Someone is reluctant to admit their project is behind schedule (FIRST R19, R24)

"An honest 'we're behind' said early is far more useful, and far less costly, than a schedule that quietly stops matching reality. This isn't about blame — it's about staying useful."

A participant feels their project is "too simple" to warrant formal closure (FIRST R28)

"Even a simple project benefits from a genuine moment of confirming it's actually done and capturing what you'd do differently — that habit is what this FIRST is really building."

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS (one a full arc) where participants commonly get stuck or hesitant — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST R4

Project Requirements Gathered

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants may not have direct access to a real stakeholder to interview (e.g., a personal project with no external stakeholder). Have them role-play the exercise using a real past request they received, reconstructing what the actual underlying need likely was in hindsight.

FIRST R21–R23

Agile Project Experience, Scrum Experience, Kanban Workflow

FACILITATOR NOTE

Participants without direct professional Agile experience may feel like they have nothing genuine to contribute here. Reframe explicitly: these three FIRSTS are about building awareness and vocabulary now, so that when they do encounter these methodologies professionally, they're not starting from zero.

FIRST R25

Project Escalation

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants may associate escalation with getting someone in trouble or admitting personal failure. Be explicit that appropriate escalation is a normal, responsible project management action, not a sign of inadequacy — the FIRST's whole point is normalizing it.

FIRST R30

End-to-End Project Managed

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is a genuinely large commitment to make in a single session. Don't let anyone leave without naming one specific, real, upcoming project — a vague future intention defeats the purpose of this capstone FIRST.